got the Chinese to recognize Sikkim as part of India, without getting an explicit political pronouncement to that effect by China. Had the Indian side insisted until the very end about securing a political iteration from China that Sikkim was part of India, the Chinese may have relented eventually since they also wanted an iteration of their own from India, on Tibet. They wanted a formulation that improved upon what Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi had given them in 1988, namely that Tibet was an autonomous region of the People's Republic of China, with a much more explicit acknowledgement. In the end, the Chinese did not explicitly acknowledge in the Joint Statement issued at the end of the Vajpayee visit that Sikkim was a part of India, but India on its part added further legitimacy to the Chinese claim over Tibet by averring in the Joint Statement that 'Tibet Autonomous Region is part of the territory of the People's Republic of China'. By itself, this statement by India was not problematic because India already considered Tibet in this way since 1954. But a unilateral declaration by India in a bilateral Joint Statement on a matter concerning the sovereignty and integrity of China on the matter of Tibet, without India securing a corresponding political recognition from China that Sikkim was part of the territory of the Republic of India, seemed like poor execution. India got half a victory when she might have had it all.

It fell to the next Government, led by Prime Minister Dr Manmohan Singh, to complete the process by securing, in the Joint Statement of 11 April 2005, the words 'Sikkim State of India'. [23] The Chinese agreed to this formulation because they wanted the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India–China Boundary Question, which was to be the centrepiece of the 2005 visit of Chinese Premier Wen Jiabao. The price that the Government of India had to pay was not just to reiterate the new formulation